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Donna Tartt's Second Act

The author of *The Secret History* returns with one of the year's most anticipated novels

by Charlotte Abbott | Sep 09, 2002



On the eve of the September 1992 publication of Donna Tartt's debut novel, *The Secret History*, the 28-year-old author was earmarked for instant celebrity. Her literary pedigree was impeccable: hailed as a "genius" at age 16 by fellow Mississippian and former *Harper's* magazine editor Willie Morris, Tartt had begun her highbrow thriller while studying at Bennington College, a literary backdrop made famous by the novels of her schoolmate and friend, Bret Easton Ellis.

All the pieces of a headline-grabbing launch were in place. The previous year, Knopf had won Tartt's book in a fierce auction for a reported \$450,000—an even more princely sum in those days. Within months, the house had sold rights in 11 countries for more than \$500,000, and paperback rights for another \$510,000, while agent Binky Urban optioned film rights to Alan Pakula, director of *All the President's Men*. Two printings of the galley and Tartt's splashy appearance at the annual ABA convention had kicked up word-of-mouth among booksellers and in the media. And the hardcover, which was packaged in an elongated trim with a distinctive celluloid jacket, had an announced first printing of 75,000 copies.

Agog at Tartt's erudition and smitten by her "Norma Desmond sunglasses and dark, bobbed hair," *Vanity Fair* sealed her fate by devoting seven pages to the Lolita-sized literary figure who could spout Nabokov and Eliot by heart.

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While *Esquire*, *Vogue*, *Elle* and *Mirabella* touted the novel as the debut of the year, critics at daily papers and newsmagazines clamored to review it upon its publication. In the *New York Times*, Michiko Kakutani described it as a cross between "the plot of Dostoyevsky's *Crime and Punishment* [and] the story of Euripides' *Bacchae* set against the backdrop of Bret Easton Ellis's *Rules of Attraction* and told in the elegant, ruminative voice of Evelyn Waugh's *Brideshead Revisited*." *Time* hailed it as "the novel that has everything: chills, thrills, campus scandals, literary jokes."

Two days after pub, *Newsweek* backhandedly acknowledged Tartt's runaway success in an article by Laura Shapiro titled "Anatomy of a Hype." Quoting an unnamed editor who claimed that "the landscape is littered with the corpses of overpraised young writers," Shapiro wondered if "such a gigantic fuss is in the best interest of a first-time author." As if to underscore the point, Richard Eder delivered a scathing assessment of the book in the *Los Angeles Times* a few days later, charging that Tartt was "free with attributes and stingy with character" and that the book's second half "sags badly." Other mixed reviews followed.

Though *The Secret History* became an international bestseller, and remained on the *PW* bestseller list for three months, Tartt was dogged by Shapiro's question, often posed by subsequent interviewers who insinuated that she was a "one-hit wonder." During those endless interviews, the young author took care to shield the second novel she had begun writing from the media's gaze. "It

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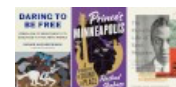
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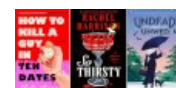
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young author took care to ensure the second novel she had begun writing from the media's gaze. "It was a real lifeline," she told *PW* at a recent meeting over green tea and finger sandwiches in a Japanese tearoom on Manhattan's Upper East Side. "I didn't talk about it, but I knew that it was there, in a very quiet sense, when they kept asking, 'well, what are you going to do to top this?'"

Murder, with a Difference

Ten years later, Tartt's answer to that question has finally emerged, in the form of *The Little Friend* (Knopf, Nov.). Like *The Secret History*, it's set in the aftermath of a murder. Here, Harriet Cleve Dufresnes, an intensely brainy 12-year-old, commits herself to exacting retribution on the person she believes killed her brother Robin, found hanging from a tree in the family's yard when Harriet was less than a year old.

While both novels give off a whiff of evil that's reminiscent of William Golding's *Lord of the Flies*, the two couldn't be more different. Where *The Secret History* focused on an elite student clique in a homogenous New England academic community in the 1980s, *The Little Friend* ranges confidently across the surprisingly complex strata of a small Mississippi town in the early '70s, evoking relationships among several generations, as well as the intersecting lives of the white gentility, the black working class and impoverished backwoods rednecks (see Forecasts, p. 40).

According to several key booksellers, Tartt has outdone herself. "I think it's the next *Huck Finn*," said Sessalee Hensley, fiction buyer at Barnes & Noble. "It's a great American novel. I was knocked out by it." Noting that she was "not a *Secret History* fan," because that book's cynicism didn't appeal to her, Hensley explained that she had originally estimated her order for *The Little Friend* before she read the book. Once she picked it up, Hensley was "hooked from the first page. You know a dark incident shaped this family's life, and she reveals it so masterfully," she commented.

"The structure is great." The book also appealed to Hensley as someone who grew up in the South: "She has a huge command of the language, and does a great job of capturing the vernacular." When Hensley finished the novel, she tripled her order.

At Boston's Harvard Bookstore, manager Carol Horne declared the book "terrific," adding, "there are some scenes in there that are among the most harrowing I've read. When I got to the last chapter, I stopped and waited until the weekend, because I knew I wasn't going to be able to put the book down until I was finished. And I was glad I did." In terms of overall quality, Horne compared the book to Leif Enger's *Peace Like a River* and Jonathan Franzen's *The Corrections*—two books, she noted, that went on to win major awards last year.

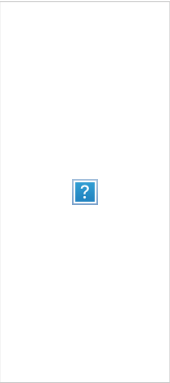
Tartt acknowledged that in her second book, she set challenges for herself that would allow her to grow as a writer. One was to widen the social canvas. Another was to assume a broader point of view. While *The Secret History* was told from a single perspective, deriving its suspense from a narrator who doesn't fully understand what's going on around him, *The Little Friend* is told from an omniscient viewpoint that drops down into the minds of various characters.

"I don't want to sound pretentious," said Tartt with a laugh that acknowledged she had been portrayed that way before, "but the point of view that I wrote this book from is the Tolstoyan view. It's like *War and Peace*—not in any way approaching merit, but in terms of structure. Technically, that's comparable to the symphonic voice. It's widely thought to be the most difficult form." Pausing carefully, she added, "I guess the most difficult thing would be to invent your own form. But in terms of traditional form, [the Tolstoyan viewpoint] is pretty hard." Laughing again, she added, "I mean, it seemed really difficult to me."

Another hurdle, Tartt added, was writing from a child's point of view. "I will tell you that is not easy. There are two children, a boy and a girl, and [I had] to try to distinguish them," she said. But Tartt remains as unsentimental as ever: "The trick in writing about children is to resist the temptation to make them lovable. Children perceive things quite clearly, but their emotional motivations are murky and often quite primitive, and they don't always entirely understand what they see."

Great Expectations

The wild success of Tartt's first novel brought with it the expectation that she would quickly produce another bestseller. Yet, ironically, Tartt's royalties from the sales of more than one million hardcovers and paperbacks in the U.S., as well as more than 21 foreign editions of *The Secret History*, granted her the freedom to resist that pressure. "Those were not the rules I wanted to play by. I can't think of anything worse than having a big success, and then trying to rush out another big success," she commented.



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Publishing news from across the Web

- Missouri Bookstore Rises Again**
After closing its doors in January, Afterword Tavern & Shelves announced that it will reopen this summer in a new Kansas City location.
- Romance Bookshop to Shutter in Kansas**
Blush Bookstore in Wichita is closing at the end of the month.
- N.C. Bookshop Celebrates Grand Opening**
Bright Side Books & Wine officially opened its doors in Raleigh last weekend.
- PEN/Benenson Courage Award Winner**

The Rutherford County Library Alliance, a coalition of library advocates in Murfreesboro, Tenn., will receive this year's PEN/Benenson Courage Award for its opposition to a library board order to remove children's books deemed "inappropriate."

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"If there's a challenge we have as a publisher," said Knopf publicity director Paul Bogaards, "it's on the retail side. There's a generation of buyers and readers out there who weren't around when the first book came out." But Bogaards was quick to point to the substantial backlist sales of *The Secret History* as the surest antidote to bookseller skepticism about Tartt's continuing appeal. At Borders, fiction buyer Bridget Mason confirmed that the book is a "core title" that has been actively stocked at all retail locations since its original publication, and has "sold really well for a 10-year-old book."

Langer's excitement doesn't surprise Carl Lennertz, program director for BookSense, the marketing arm of the Association of American Booksellers. "There's a good buzz on this one," he observed, adding that the book is "tracking" for the November BookSense '76, a list of titles recommended by independent booksellers.

If Knopf has anything to do with it, everyone will know who Donna Tartt is before the end of October. In an unusual move, the house has agreed to serialize the prologue and first chapter of the book from October 15 to 22 on the Web site dailycandy.com, which reaches "the most influential movers and shakers in the media, art, fashion and PR worlds," said Bogaards. Appearances on the *Today* show (October 24) and *NPR* will air as the long-lead glossies deliver their reviews. And major newspapers should weigh in shortly after 275,000 copies of the book hit the stores.

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